

THE MOTOWN UNIVERSE

Executive Development Memo #009 — Phase 1, Film 1: Lead Character & Release Date

CONFIDENTIAL • An alternate-reality “what if” • Fidelity Rating: 100% • Nerf Tolerance: 0%

1. The Decision

LEAD CHARACTER: Berry Gordy

RELEASE DATE: Friday, May 1, 2009

Phase 1, Film 1 • The Iron Man role • The film that kicks everything off

2. Why Berry Gordy

Iron Man worked because Tony Stark was a flawed, brilliant self-made builder, and the whole MCU grew out of what he built. In Motown history, only one person fits that role, and he really lived it.

Iron Man / Tony Stark	Berry Gordy (documented history)
A builder who makes something world-changing from almost nothing	Started Tamla Records in 1959 with an \$800 loan from his family's savings fund
Takes an industrial idea and uses it in a new way	Took what he learned on the Lincoln-Mercury assembly line and applied it to music: writing, producing, artist development and Quality Control, as a hit factory
A turning point: realizes he's working for the wrong system	Wrote hits for Jackie Wilson, such as “Reet Petite” and “Lonely Teardrops”, but was paid very little. With Smokey Robinson urging him on, he decided to own his work himself
Brilliant, charming and flawed	A former boxer, an Army veteran and a failed record-store owner. Competitive, controlling and relentless, and a genius at spotting talent
Builds the headquarters	Hitsville U.S.A., 2648 West Grand Blvd, Detroit
The anchor the whole franchise grows from	Every Motown artist's story runs through Gordy, so he is the thread across the whole universe (Memo #005)

- **Whose franchise it is:** Berry Gordy's. He anchors the Motown Universe the way Tony Stark anchored the MCU.

- **No-Nerf:** Gordy is shown at full strength, with his genius and his flaws, exactly as the record documents them.
- **Secrecy:** to the public, this is simply a biopic of Motown's founder. That is the most natural first film there is, and it gives nothing away (Memo #007).

3. Other Characters Considered for Film 1

Candidate	Verdict
Berry Gordy	SELECTED. The founder. Motown's story starts with him.
Smokey Robinson	Not for Film 1. His story branches off from Gordy's, so he's saved for his own full-strength film later.
Any headline star (the Supremes, Stevie Wonder, Marvin Gaye and others)	Not for Film 1. Their stories need Hitsville to exist first, and each deserves their own full film.

4. Release Date: Friday, May 1, 2009

- **It's the MCU slot.** *Iron Man* opened on Friday, May 2, 2008, the first Friday in May. We open on the first Friday in May 2009, one year later (Memo #001).
- **It's the start of summer.** The biggest launch window of the year gives Film 1 the best chance to succeed.

Update to Memo #001: two key dates

Date	Event	Why
Mon. Jan 12, 2009	Film announced publicly at Hitsville U.S.A., Detroit	Motown's 50th anniversary to the day. It's announced only as a biopic of Motown's founder.
Tue. Apr 14, 2009	World premiere at the Fox Theatre, Detroit	The anniversary of Motown Record Corporation's incorporation (April 14, 1960). It falls about two and a half weeks before release, a timeline like <i>Iron Man</i> 's.
Fri. May 1, 2009	Wide release	The first Friday of May, the <i>Iron Man</i> slot.

Why the premiere moved: Memo #001 put the premiere on Jan 12. A premiere 16 weeks before release would let reviews and post-credits scenes leak for months, which breaks the Secrecy Mandate. Jan 12 is now the announcement date instead, so the anniversary is still celebrated.

5. Next Step

The full Memo #008 film sheet has not been filled in yet: title, source material, synopsis, antagonist, timeline, world-building, post-credits scenes and how it kicks everything off. It will be completed in the next memo.

TMU is a fan-made alternate-reality concept. It has no connection to Motown Records, Universal, Paramount or Marvel Studios. The people named are real, and their roles here are fictional.